



Education Indicator

EDUCATION AND LEARNING OUTCOMES

Participation in early childhood education

Overall, early childhood education (ECE) participation increased from 2024 to 2025, across the three early learning participation measurements the Ministry of Education publishes. Among the population of ECE-aged children (0-4 years old), 64% participated in ECE in 2025. Six-months prior to entering school, 96.8% of children participated in ECE. Among 3-year-olds, 77% attended for 10 hours or more and 41% attended for 20 hours or more. Among 4-year-olds, 83% attended ECE for at least 10 hours or more and 43% attended ECE for 20 hours or more.

Indicator description

This report presents three indicators of children's participation in early learning:

- **Population-based participation (PBP):** This measures the percentage of children attending early learning services out of the projected aged 0–4-year-old national population.¹
- **Participation intensity measurement (PIM):** This measures the percentage of children aged three and four who attend ECE for an average of 10 or more, or 20 or more hours per week.² PIM includes all licensed services except kōhanga reo.
- **Prior participation rate (PPR):** This measures the percentage of children who regularly attended early learning services in the six months prior to starting school between 1 July and 30 June each year, based on information provided by parents upon enrolment at school and attendance records from the Early Learning Information (ELI) system.

These measurements are summarised in Figure 1.

¹ Based on Stats NZ dataset *National ethnic population projections, by age and sex, 2018 (base)-2043*.

² The participation intensity measure in ECE is calculated using data from the early learning information (ELI) system. Ngā kōhanga reo do not yet report their data via ELI. Based on Stats NZ dataset *National ethnic population projections, by age and sex, 2018 (base)-2043*, 50th percentile (median) scenario.

Figure 1: The three measurements of ECE participation and the age groups that each cover

	Age of children					
	0	1	2	3	4	5
Population-based participation	What proportion of the projected population are attending an early learning service?					
Participation intensity measurement				What percentage of children (out of the projected population) are attending for 10 and/or 20 hours or more, on average?		
Prior participation rate					What percentage of children attended an early learning service in the six months prior to starting school?	

The ECE Census datasets are based around the June 2025 ECE Census week. Comparisons are made to the previous year to indicate year-on-year change and to 2019, to illustrate trends.

ECE services refers to all licensed services including education and care services, kindergartens, playcentres, home-based services and kōhanga reo.³

Why this is important

Several studies have identified links between participation in early learning and better social and economic outcomes for children when they reach older ages, such as higher earning, reduced reliance on the welfare programmes and lower crime rates (Mitchell et al., 2008).

Studies show that engagement in early learning results in educational and vocational gains and reduces social inequalities in academic performance in adulthood. Children from low socio-economic backgrounds especially benefited from early learning participation, with research showing that early learning participation is associated with better social interactions, emotional maturity and greater learning abilities (Bakken et al., 2017, Campbell et al., 2008).

Early learning is a cost-effective way of closing achievement gaps before they widen and become entrenched. Policies for early learning that are co-ordinated and evidence-based can reduce the need for expensive remedial education and social services in the future (OECD, 2025). In New Zealand, children who participate in early learning generally have better developed social and emotional skills before starting school and perform better in maths, reading, communication and logical problem-solving during their primary school and adolescent years (Thomas et al., 2019; Wylie & Thompson, 2003; OECD, 2016).

³ Puna Reo, Reo Rua Education and Care, bilingual Leo o Fanau Moana and immersion Leo o Fanau Moana services are included under education and care service types. These service types were established in 2025.

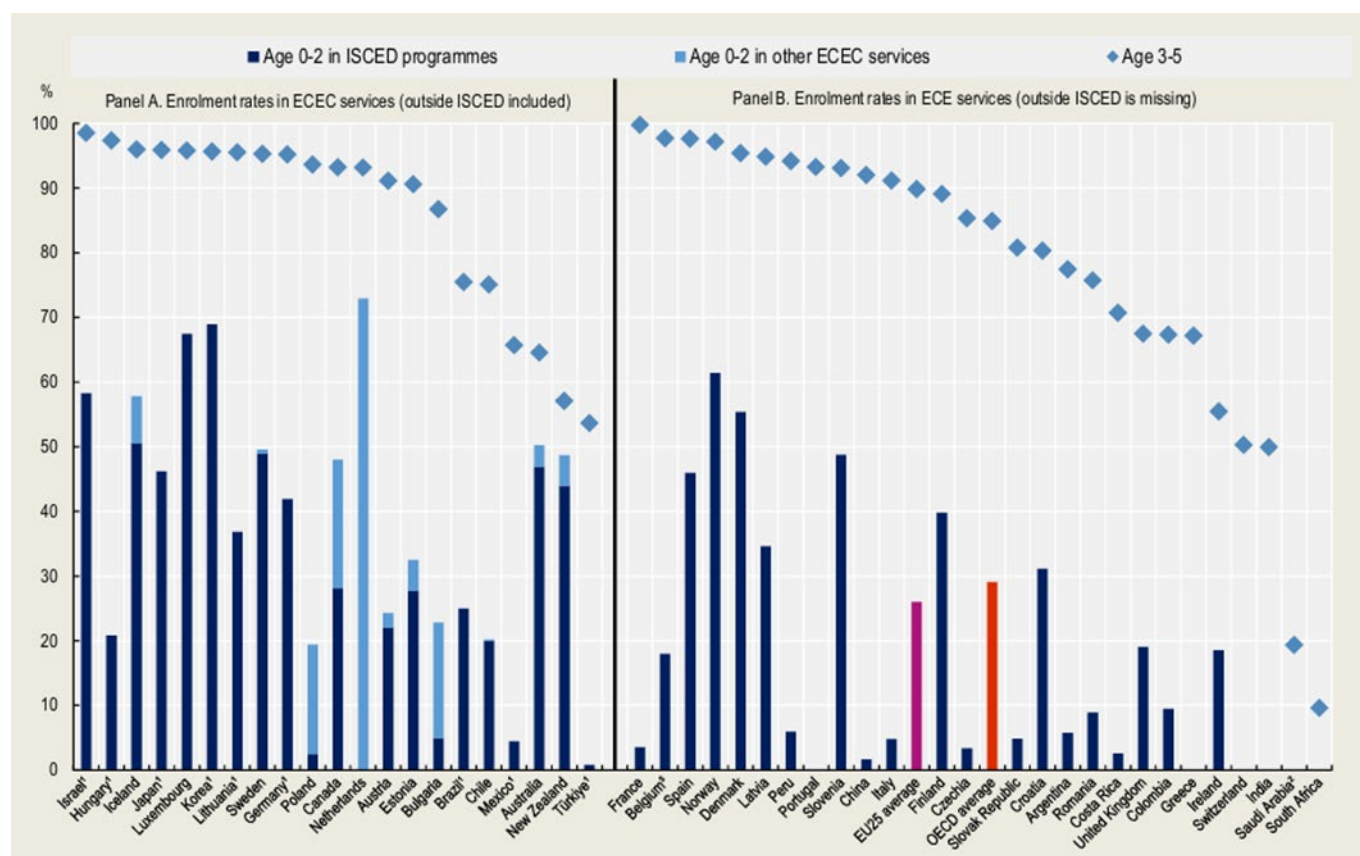
Emphasis on the benefits of early childhood education varies across research sources and across jurisdictions. However, research suggests that there are benefits of regular participation in early childhood education for development and it can impact further compulsory learning and life outcomes in positive ways (Ansari et al., 2019, Bailey et al., 2017, Jenkins et al., 2016).

How do New Zealand ECE participation rates compare internationally?

The 2025 edition of the OECD's Education at a Glance, which is based on 2023 data, showed New Zealand's position against other OECD nations (Figure 2). In 2023, New Zealand's participation rates in ECE were as follows:

- Under three-year-olds was 45% - above the OECD average of 29%.
- Three-year-olds was 84% - above the OECD average of 79%.
- Four-year-olds was 87% - below the OECD average of 90%.

Figure 2: Percentage of 0- to 5-year-olds in ECE, across OECD nations (2023)⁴



⁴ Some countries have other registered ECEC services that are considered to be an integral part of their ECEC provision but do not comply with all the ISCED 2011 Level 0 criteria to qualify as educational programmes.

¹ There are no ECEC services that fall outside ISCED classification.

² Year of reference differs from 2013.

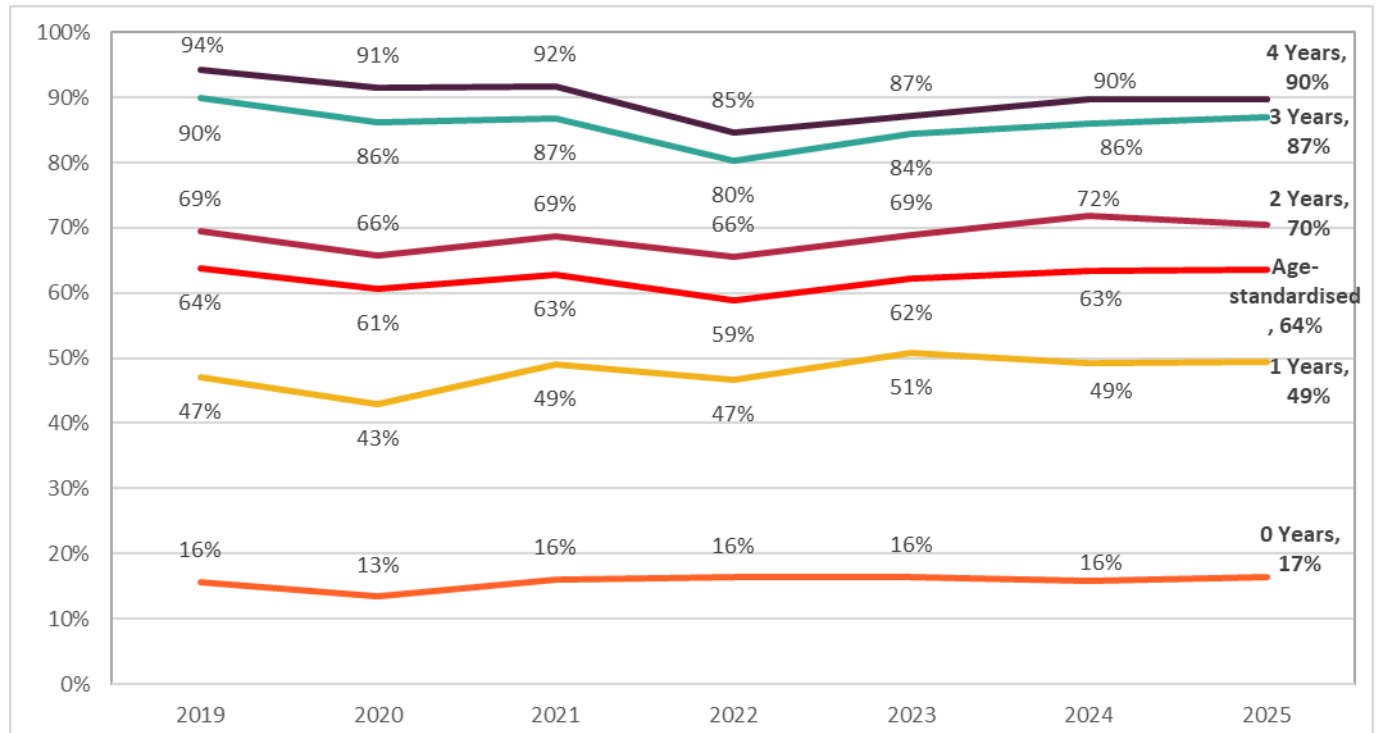
³ Year of reference differs from 2023.

What happened to ECE participation in 2025?

After an initial drop in ECE participation post-Covid, participation has been slowly increasing since 2023 and in 2025 it reached levels similar to that in 2019 (to pre-Covid levels).

There was an increase in the age-standardised ECE PBP—from 63% in 2024 to 64% in 2025.⁵ The PBP rate for children of age 0 and 3 attending a licensed ECE service increased, while the rate for children of age 1 and 4 remained the same (Figure 3). Only children of age 2 had a decline in the PBP rate.

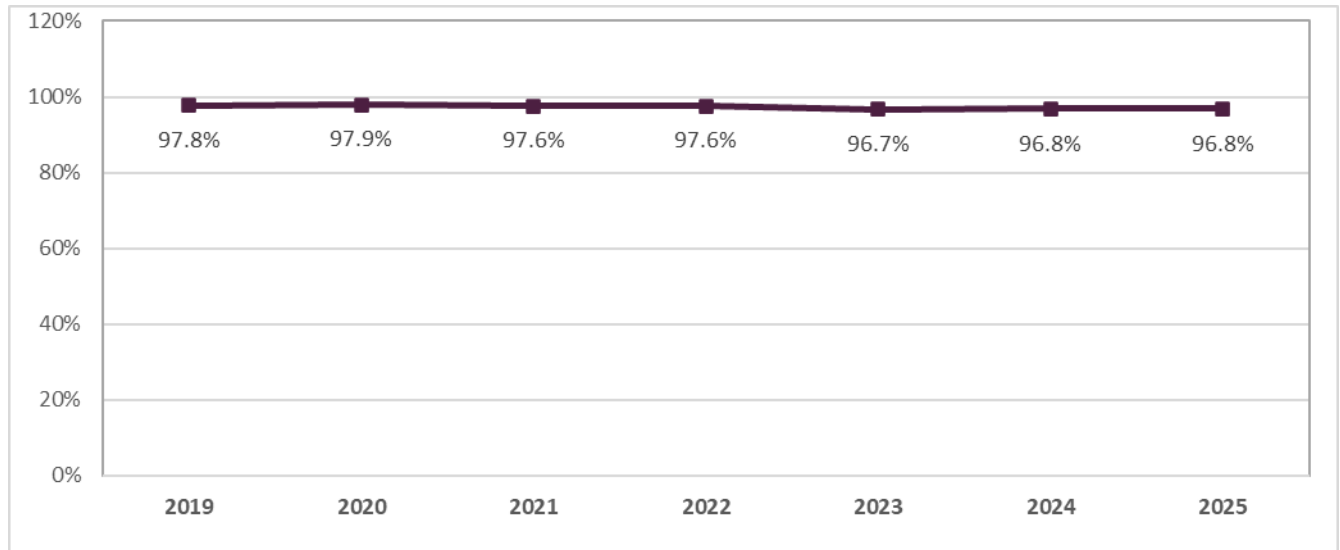
Figure 3: Population-based participation (PBP) by age



From 2019 to 2022, the trend in the PPR had remained fairly stable at around 98%, and slightly decreased in 2023 to below 97% (Figure 4). In 2025, the PPR was 96.8%, the same as that in 2024 and a change of 0.1 percentage point from 2023.

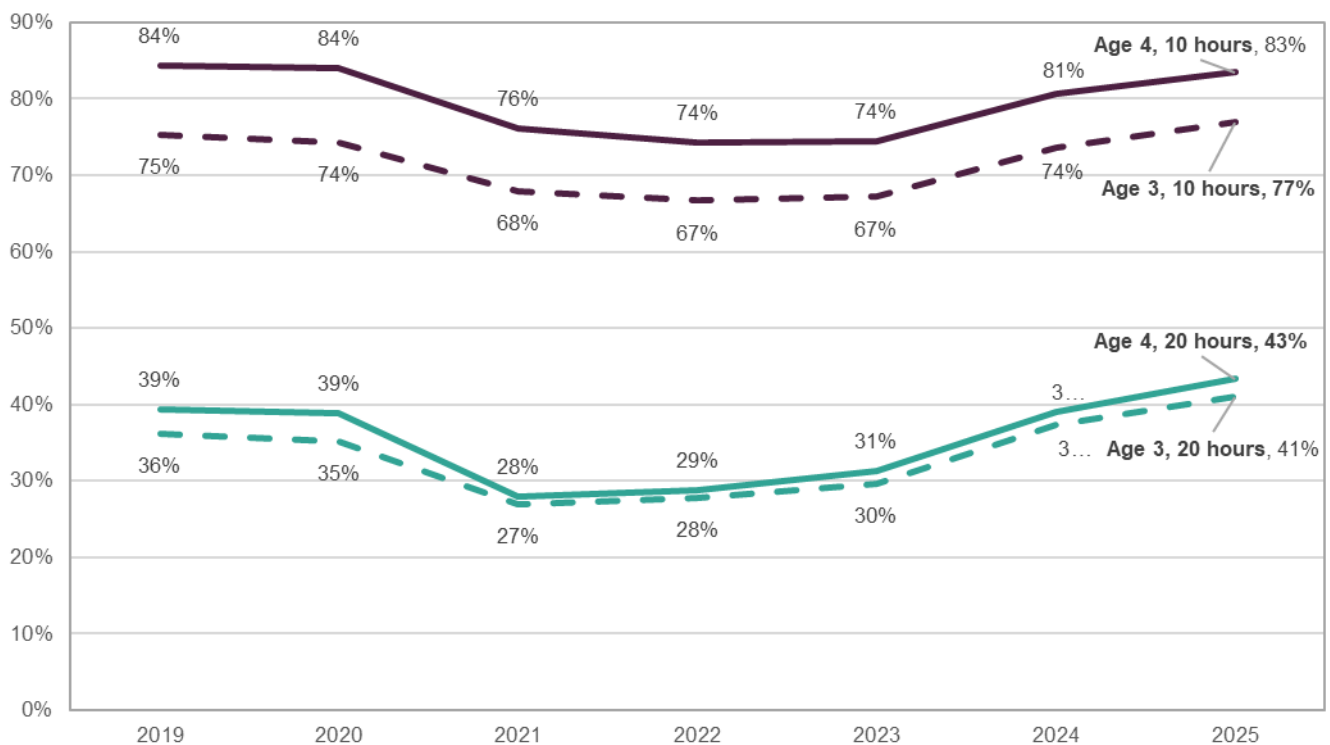
⁵ Age standardisation is a process of adjusting for a population's proportion of enrolments to account for changes in the age structure of the population over time. Age-standardised PBP is the standardised average of ECE participation by children of ages 0-4 years.

Figure 4: Change in ECE prior participation rate (PPR) from 2019 to 2025



The PIM increased for children aged 3 and 4 across both the 10 hours and 20 hours measurements, from 2024 to 2025 (Figure 5). Among 4-year-olds, the 10 hours or more PIM increased from 81% in 2024 to 83% in 2025; the 20 hours or more PIM increased from 39% to 43%. For 3-year-olds, the 10 hours or more PIM increased from 74% to 77%; and the 20 hours or more PIM increased from 37% to 41%.

Figure 5: ECE participation intensity measurements (PIM) from 2019- 2025



This was also an increase from 2022, when the impacts of COVID-19 had the most significant impacts on the PIM and PBP measures.

Participation rates for children aged 3 and 4 have declined the most since 2019.

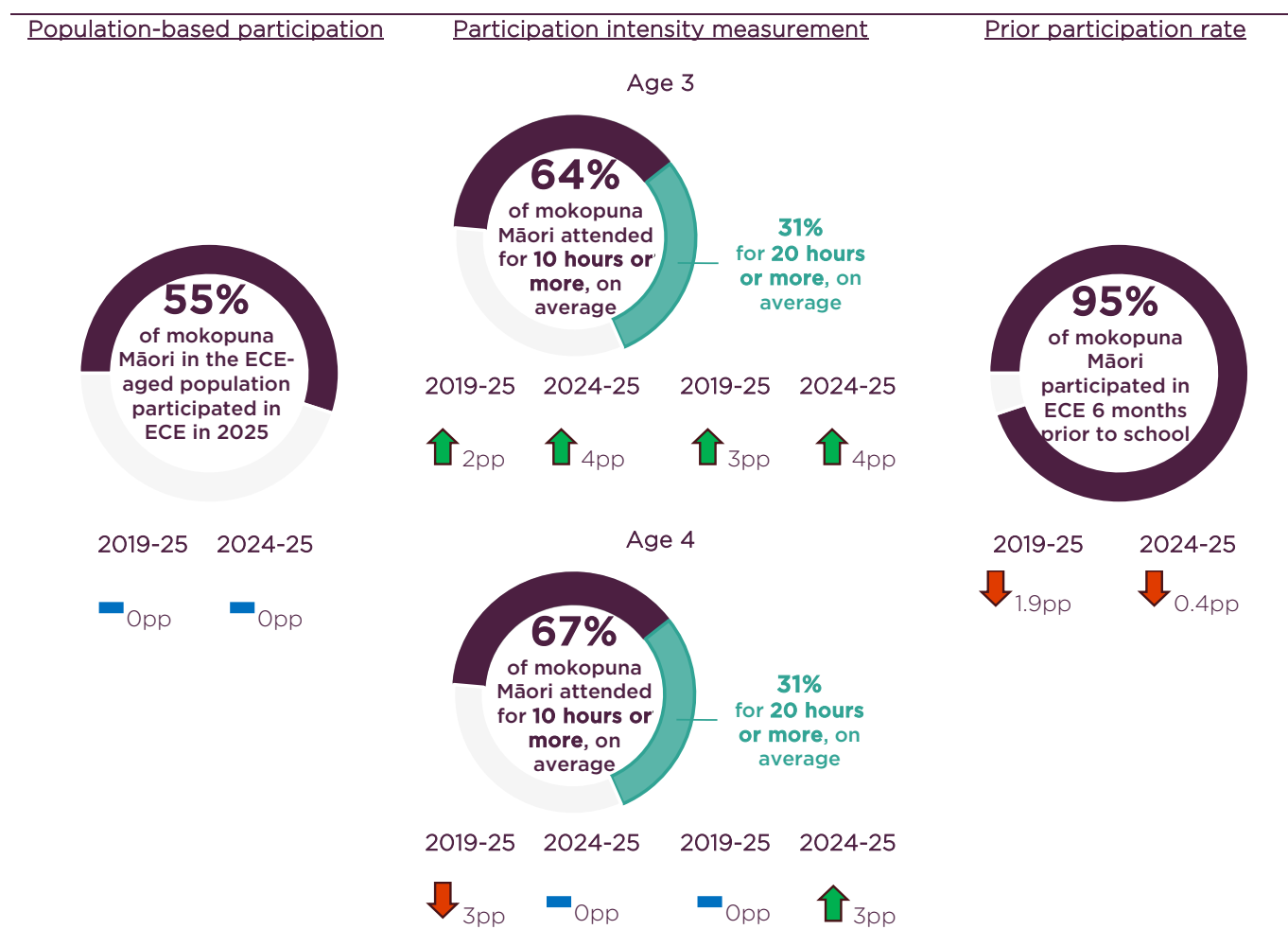
Age-standardised PBP rates have reached pre-Covid 2019 levels of 64% (see Figure 3). Since 2019, PBP increased by 1 percentage point for children aged 0 (from 16% to 17%) and children aged 2 (69% to 70%) and increased by 2 percentage points for children aged 1 (47% to 49%).

PBP rates decreased by 3 percentage points for children aged 3 (from 90% to 87%) and by 4 percentage points for children aged 4 (from 94% to 90%). A similar decline (see Figure 5) can be seen for the 10 hours PIM among 4-year-olds (from 84% to 83%). For 3-year-olds (from 75% to 77%), 10 hours PIM surpassed 2019 levels, for the first time.

What is happening for mokopuna Māori?

Most participation measurements for mokopuna Māori have decreased from 2019 but increased from 2024.

As with the overall population of learners, for mokopuna Māori the PPR and PIM for most age-groups have decreased since 2019. However, proportions have been increasing since the lower rates of 2022. Between 2024 and 2025, the PBP and 10 hours or more PIM for 4-year-olds remained the same for mokopuna Māori, while the PPR decreased by 0.4 percentage points (Figure 6). The 20 hours or more PIM increased for both 3- and 4-year-olds, and the 10 hours or more PIM also increased for 3-year-olds. The 20 hours or more PIM, on average across both age-groups, had the largest increase from 2024, which was in line with the overall population of children.

Figure 6: Participation measurements for mokopuna Māori^{6,7}

It is worth noting that the PIM for mokopuna Māori is undercounted to an unknown extent, because kōhanga reo are not connected to ELI. Given that 17% of mokopuna Māori who attended licensed services during the 2025 ECE Census were at a kōhanga reo, this will be a considerable number of mokopuna Māori children that are not counted.

⁶ The down arrow and the up arrow depict a negative and positive year-on-year percentage point difference, respectively. The blue circle indicates data was not available. The number next to these arrows indicate the value of percentage point (pp) difference.

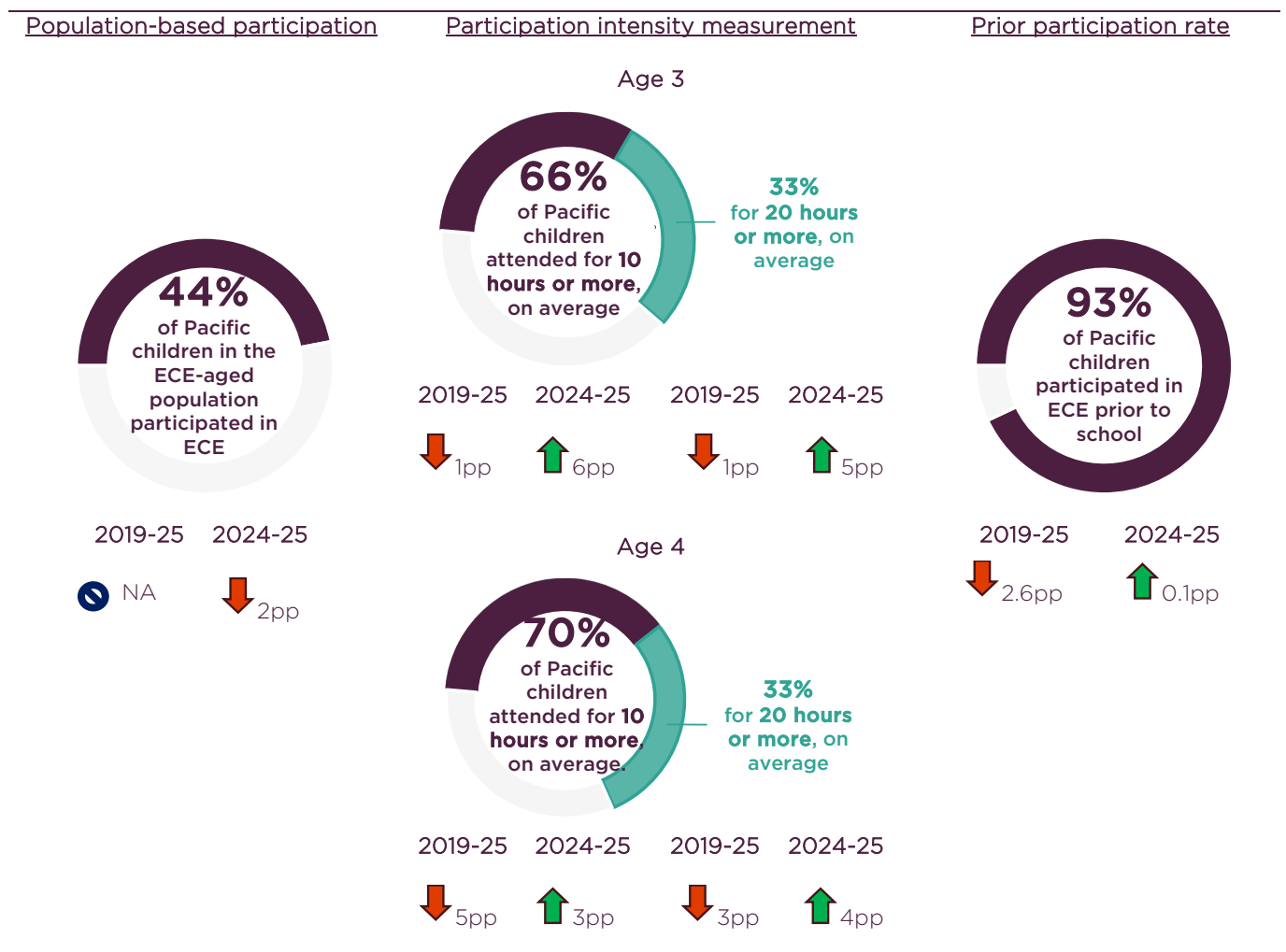
⁷ Percentage point changes are labelled as stable if they round to 0 dp.

What is happening for Pacific children?

Most measurements showed an increase in participation among Pacific children from 2024 to 2025.

The number of Pacific children participating in ECE fell considerably between 2019 and 2025 (Figure 7). This is particularly evident in the PIM figures. Some of the large decreases in the PIM for Pacific children may have been because Pacific children are primarily based in Auckland. Between 2020-2022, Auckland experienced the most impact from COVID-19 alert level and protection framework settings that required people to stay home. After considerable falls in participation rates for Pacific children between 2019 and 2025, the PPR and all metrics for PIM among 3- and 4-year-olds have increased.

Figure 7: Participation measurements for Pacific children⁸

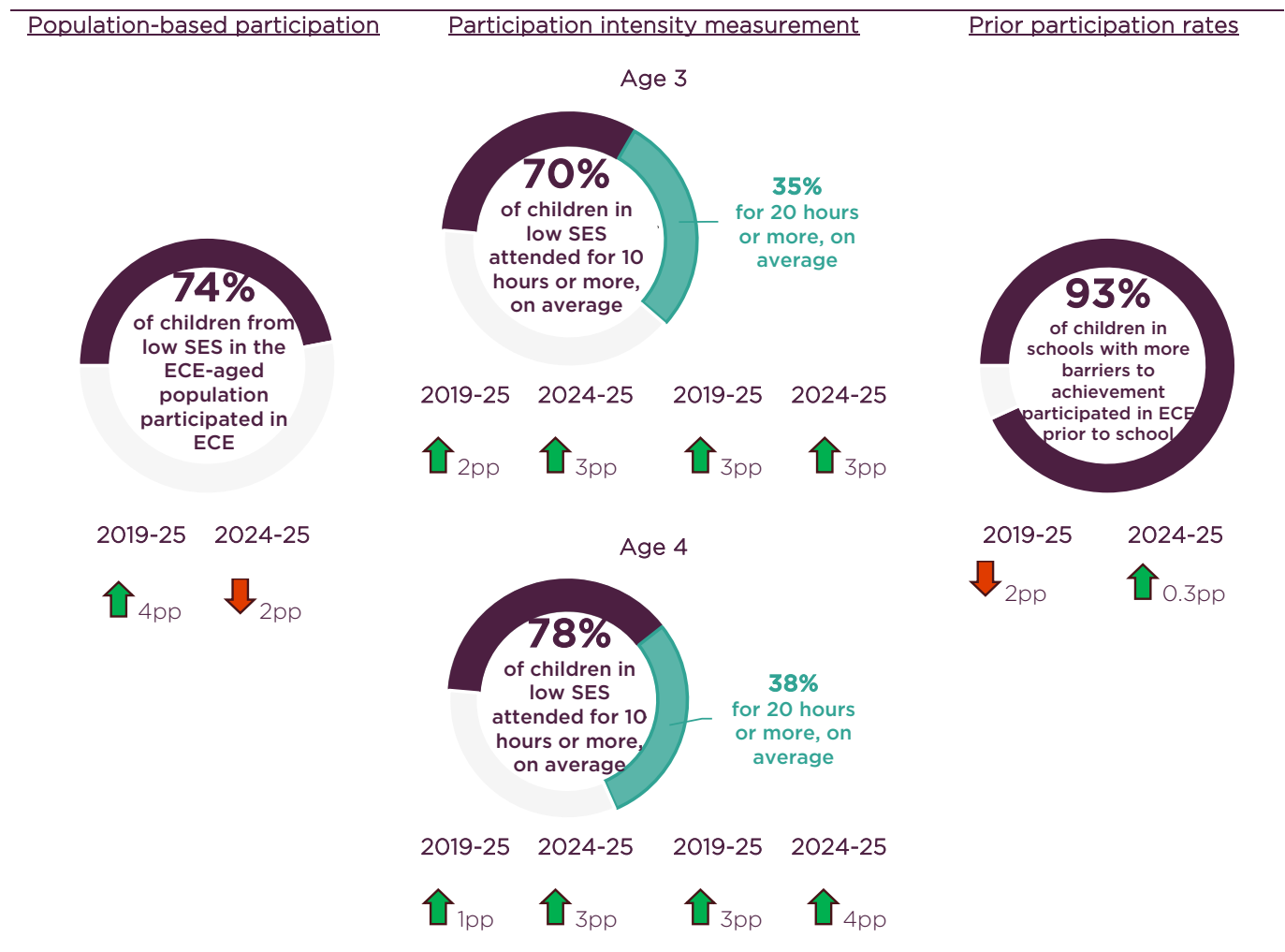


⁸ Participation of Pacific children is best reported using total response ethnicity. Total response data has been recorded in the ECE Census from 2021 onwards.

What is happening for children in low socioeconomic areas?

In 2025, for the first time since 2019, PIM for children in all socioeconomic areas increased. There were also increases of at least 2 percentage points for each PIM category since 2024 (Figure 8). Children in schools with more barriers to achievement had a fall in the PPR since 2019 but had a 0.3 percentage point increase between 2024 and 2025.⁹ Children in low socioeconomic groups had higher PBP rates (74%), compared to those in medium (69%) and high socioeconomic groups (46%).

Figure 8: Participation measurements for children in low socioeconomic areas (PBP and PIM) and schools with more barriers to achievement (PPR)¹⁰



⁹ Measurements of socioeconomic status differ across the different measurements, because of how the data is collected. Socioeconomic areas are extracted from the NZ Deprivation Index variable. NZ Dep Index is a measure of socioeconomic deprivation produced by the Department of Public Health at the University of Otago, based on information from the 2018 Census. The more deprived an area, the higher the NZ Deprivation Index (the most deprived areas have a NZ Deprivation Index score of 10). The 2023 NZ deprivation index was obtained from [Stats NZ](#). The 2018 NZ deprivation index was obtained from the [University of Otago](#). In this report, an NZ deprivation index of 1-3 is considered 'high', an index of 4-7 is considered 'medium' and an index of 8-10 is considered 'low' socioeconomic area, respectively.

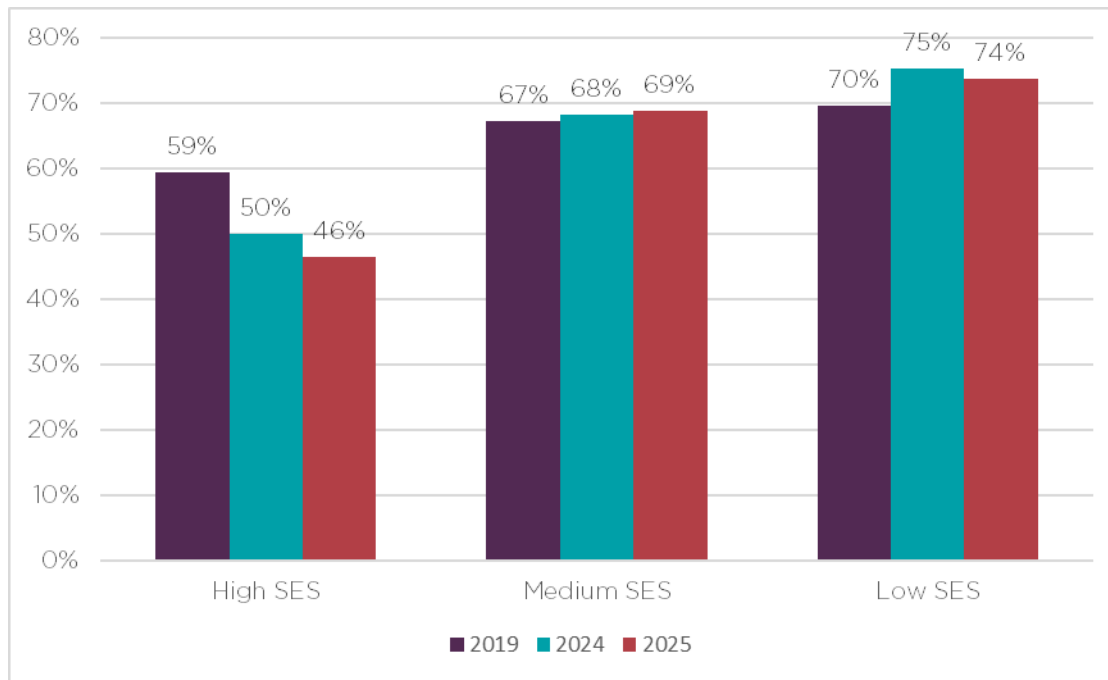
¹⁰ The Ministry has developed a method of reporting on socioeconomic trends in education statistics, called School Equity Index Bands and Groups, derived from the Schooling Equity Index. These categories estimate the extent to which, on average, students at a school face socioeconomic barriers that could get in the way of their school achievement. More information on this reporting method can be found on [Education Counts](#).

Compared to children in medium and high socioeconomic groups, and schools with moderate and fewer barriers to achievement, children in low socioeconomic groups had lower rates for PIM and PPR.

Has the gap between low, medium and high socioeconomic areas closed?

Compared to 2019, the PBP rate for children in low socioeconomic areas increased by 4 percentage points (Figure 9). PIM increased for children in low socioeconomic areas (Figure 10) but the PPR decreased for children in schools with more socioeconomic barriers (Figure 11).

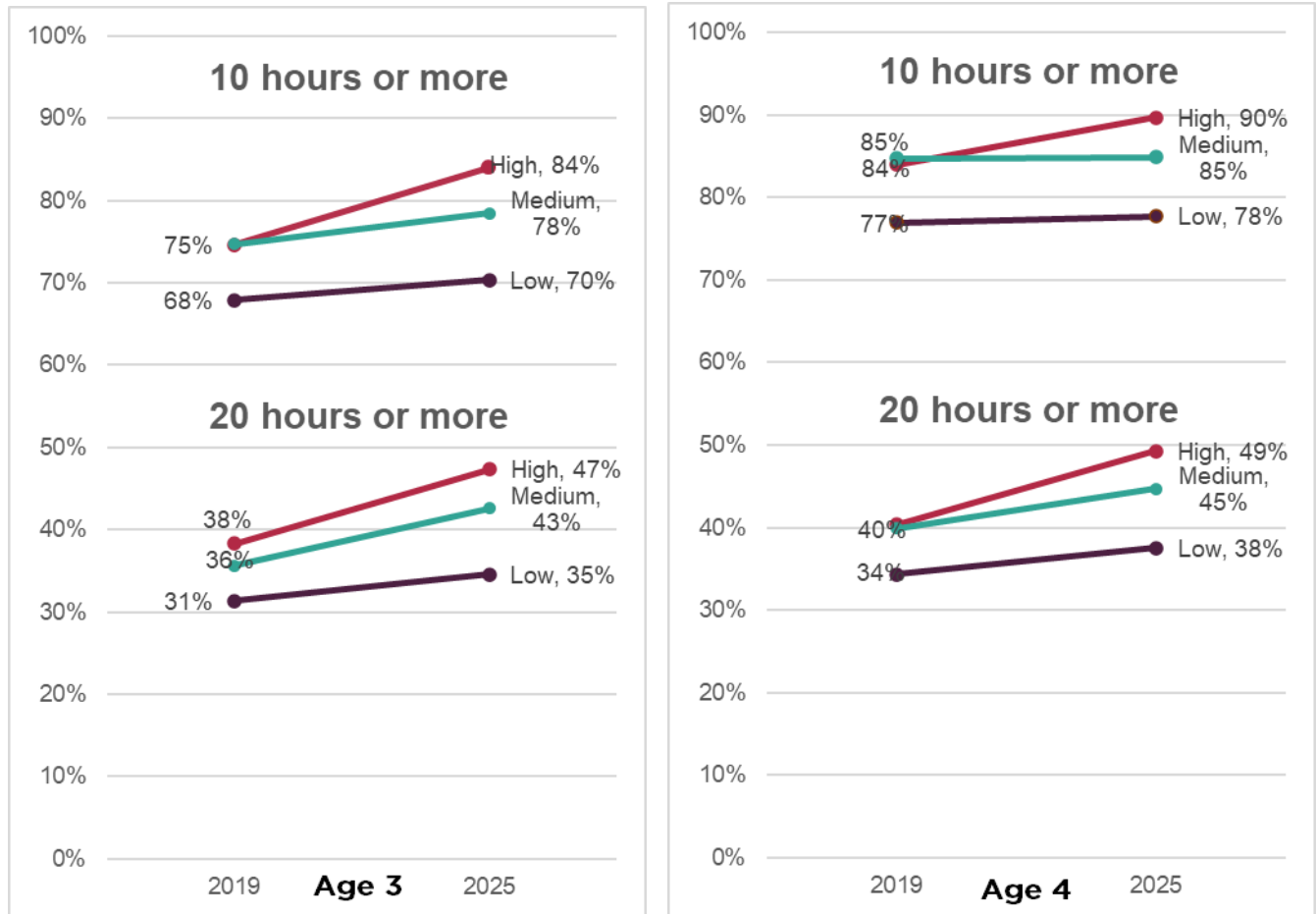
Figure 9: Population-based participation (PBP) rates in 2019, 2024 and 2025, for children in different SES groups



In comparison:

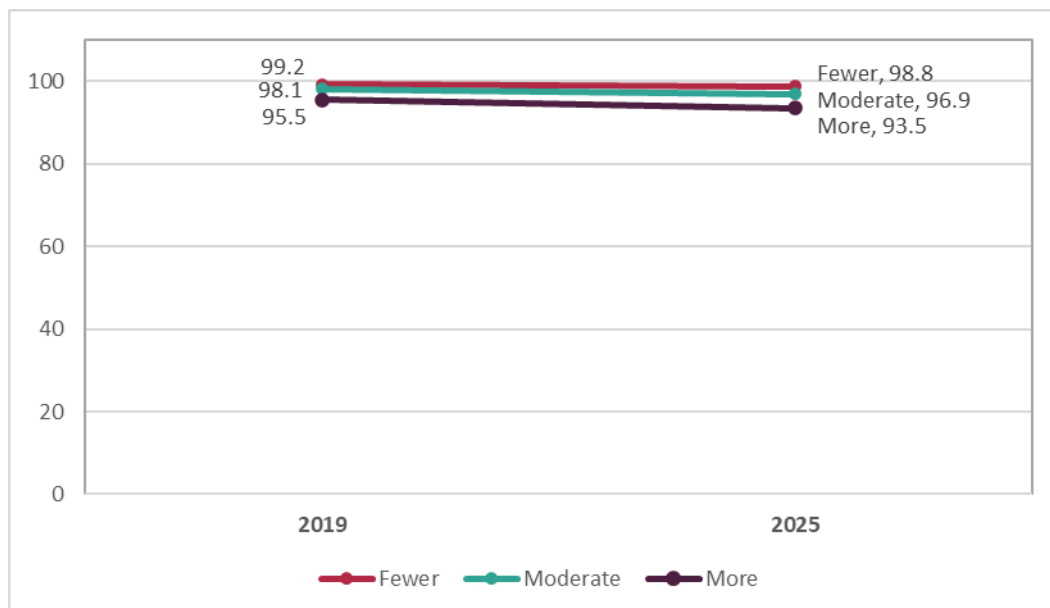
- Children in **medium socioeconomic areas** also showed an increase in all metrics for PIM among 3- and 4-year-olds (0 to 7 percentage points). The PBP rate for these children increased by 2 percentage points. The PPR for children in schools with moderate barriers to achievement decreased 1.2 percentage points.
- Children in **high socioeconomic areas** showed an increase in the PIM (6 to 9 percentage points) across all measurements. The PBP rate decreased by 13 percentage points and the PPR for these children decreased by 0.4 percentage points.

Figure 10: Participation intensity (PIM) changes between 2019 and 2025, for children in different SES groups



As a result, the gap in the PIM and the PPR between children in low socioeconomic areas and schools with more and moderate barriers, grew between 2019 and 2025, but decreased for the PBP measures.

Figure 11: Prior participation rate (PPR) changes between 2019-2025, for children in different equity index groups



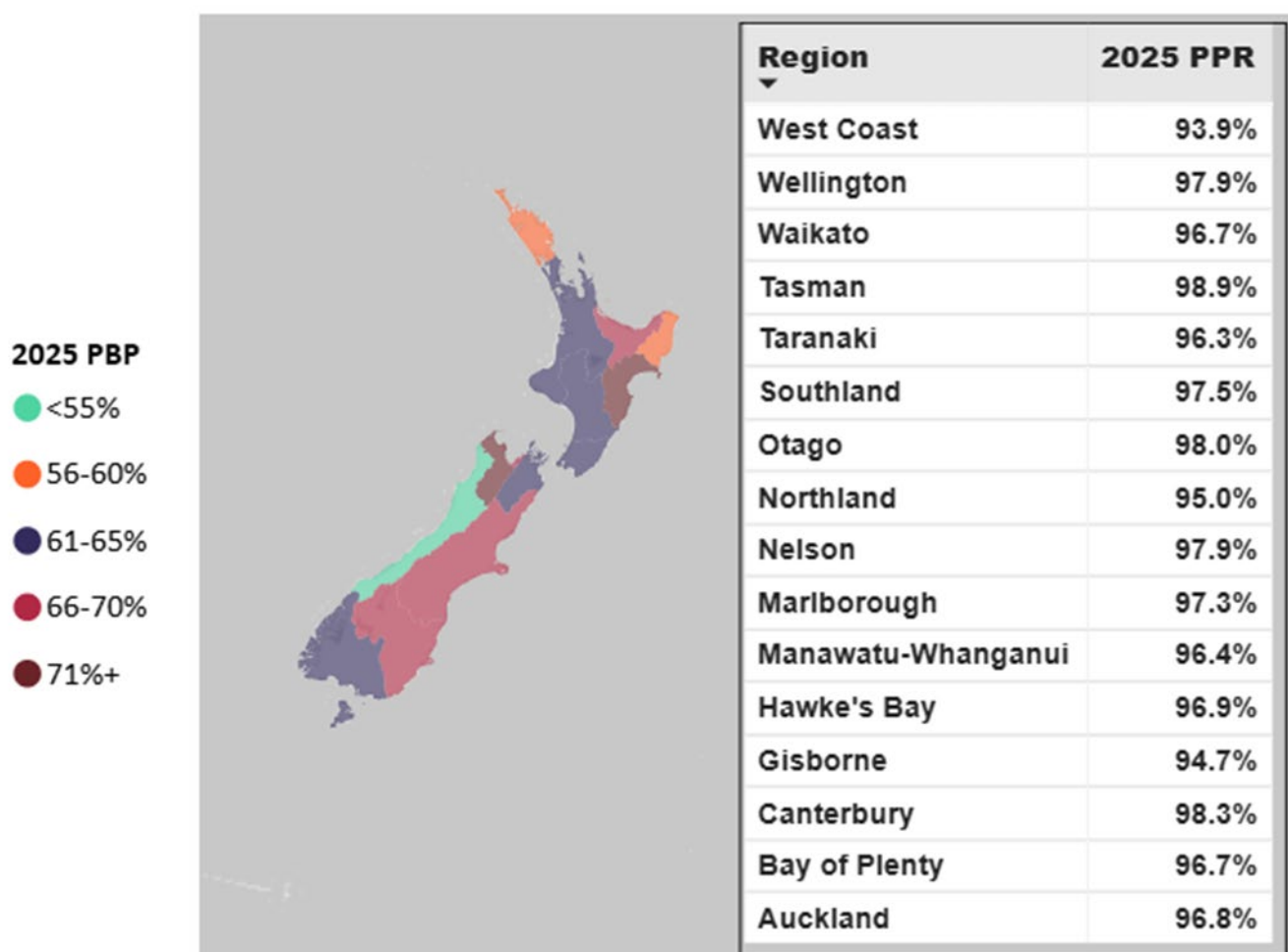
What is happening for different regions?

Over the last six years, ECE participation declined in most regions, with the West Coast and Gisborne showing the largest decline across most measurements. Auckland, Canterbury, Nelson, Tasman and Marlborough showed some increases in the participation intensity of 3- and 4-year-olds.

Hawke's Bay had the highest PBP rates for children aged 0-4 (73%) and the West Coast had the lowest (47%) rates (Figure 12). Compared to 2024, Marlborough and Hawke's Bay showed the largest increases in PBP (3 percentage points) and Auckland, Wellington and Southland showed a decrease in PBP (1 percentage point).

Tasman had the highest (99%) PPR, followed by Canterbury and Otago (98%). The PPR was 95% or above across most other regions. The West Coast (93%) and Gisborne (94%) were the only regions with a rate below 95%. Nine out of 16 regions showed a decrease in the PPR from 2024. Gisborne showed the largest decrease (2.3 percentage points) and the West Coast showed the largest increase (3.4 percentage points) in the PPR.

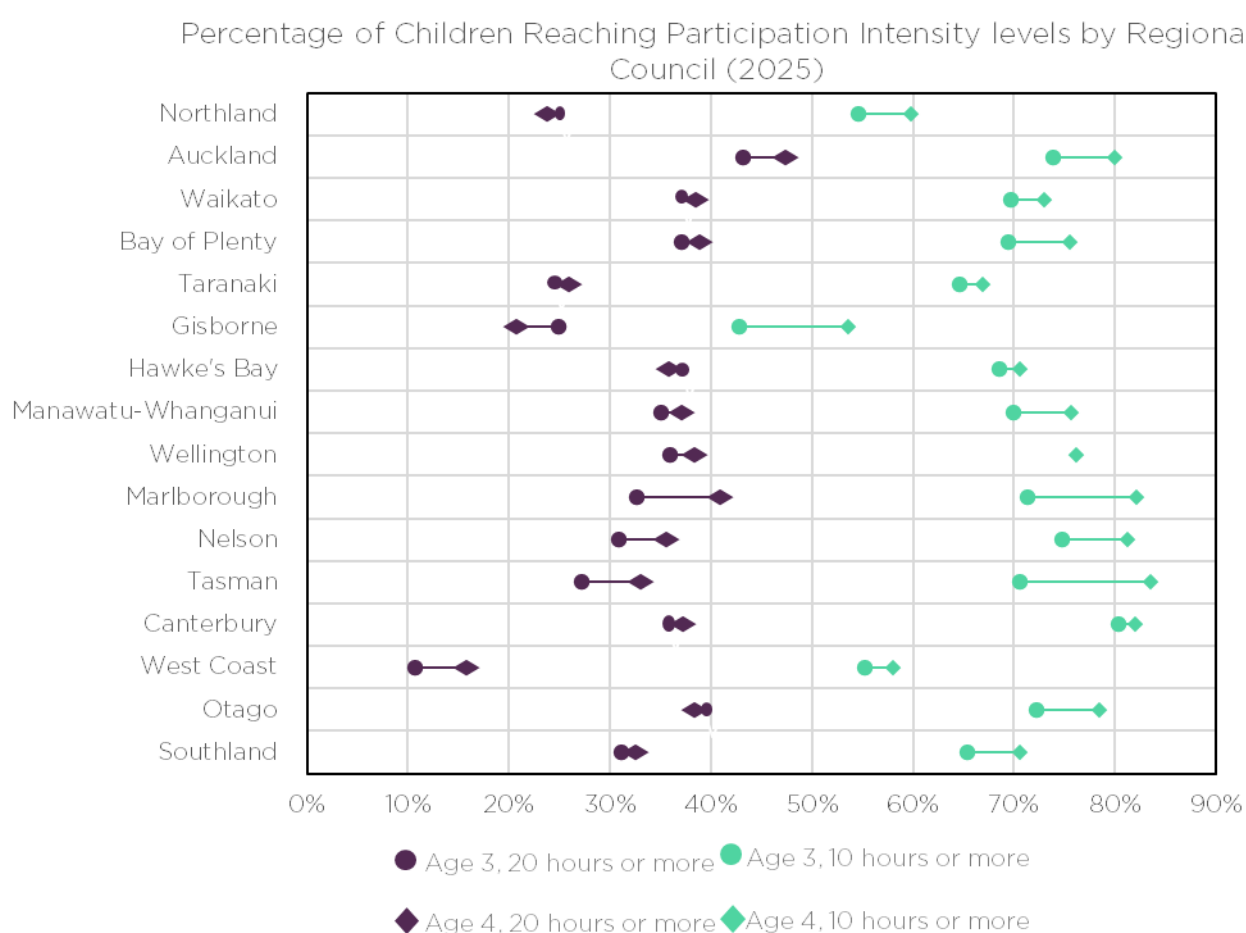
Figure 12: Population-based participation (PBP) and prior participation rate (PPR) in 2025



Children aged 3 in the Canterbury region (80%) showed the highest level of the 10 hours or more per week PIM, while children aged 3 in Auckland (43%) showed the highest level of the 20 hours or more PIM (Figure 13). Three-year-olds in Gisborne had the largest decrease in the PIM from 2024 for 10 hours or more (13 percentage points) and the West Coast had the largest decrease in 20 hours or more PIM (5 percentage points).

Among children aged 4, the Tasman region (84%) had the highest level of the 10 hours or more PIM, and those in Auckland (47%) had the highest level of the 20 hours or more PIM. Four-year-olds in Bay of Plenty (3 percentage points) showed the largest increase for 10 hours or more PIM from 2024, and those in Marlborough (7 percentage points) showed the largest increase for 20 hours or more PIM. Children of age 4 in Taranaki showed the largest decrease (14 and 5 percentage points) in both the 10 and 20 hours or more PIM, from 2024.

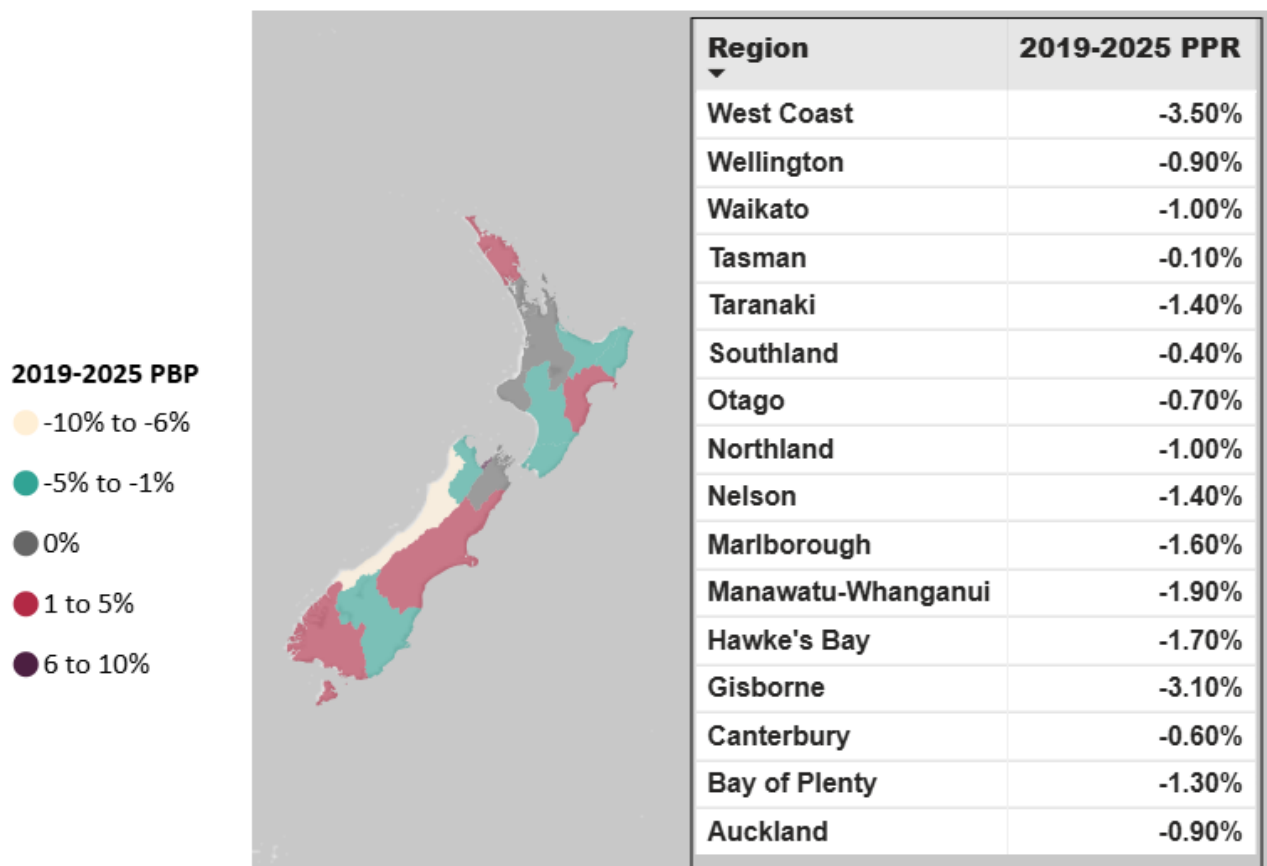
Figure 13: PIM at 10 hours or more and 20 hours or more per week among 3- and 4-year-olds, in 2025



Participation has declined in most regions since 2019

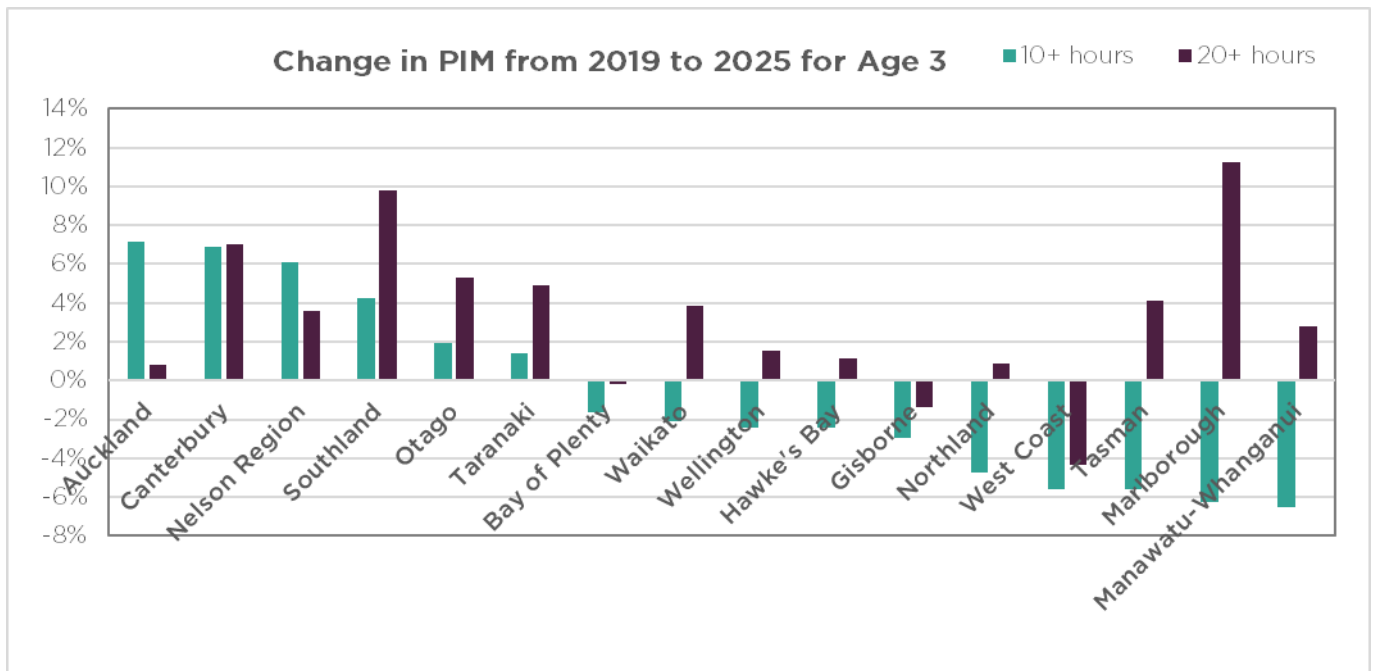
Since 2019, 9 regions showed a decline in PBP rates for children aged 0-4 participating in ECE. The West Coast region showed the largest decrease (10 percentage points) and Nelson showed the largest increase (7 percentage points) in PBP rates (Figure 14).

The PPR decreased from 2019-2025 across all regions (Figure 13). Gisborne had the largest decrease (2.7 percentage points) in the PPR.

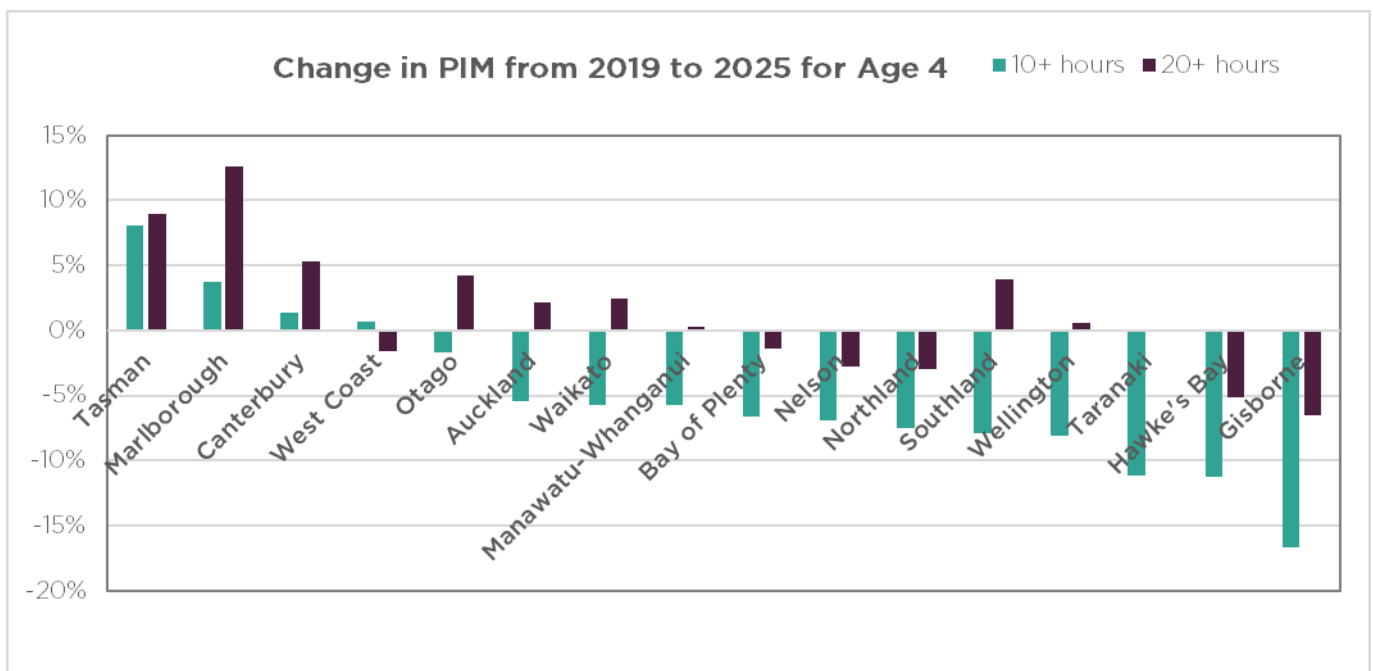
Figure 14 Change in population-based participation (PBP) and prior participation rate (PPR) from 2019-2025

Since 2019, among children aged 3, the regions with the largest PIM increases for 10 hours or more were: Auckland (7 percentage points), Canterbury (7 percentage points) and Nelson (6 percentage points) and the regions with the largest PIM increases for 20 hours or more were: Marlborough (11 percentage points), Southland (10 percentage points) and Canterbury (7 percentage points).

The largest decreases for the 10 hours or more and 20 hours or more PIM, respectively, were the Manawatu-Whanganui region (7 percentage points 10 hours or more PIM) and in the West Coast region (4 percentage points 20 hours or more PIM). (Figure 15).

Figure 15: Changes in participation intensity (PIM) for children aged 3, between 2019 and 2025

For children aged 4, the regions with the largest PIM increases for both 10 hours or more and 20 hours or more, since 2019, were: Tasman (8 percentage points 10+ hours and 9 percentage points 20+ hours) and Marlborough (4 percentage points 10+ hours and 13 percentage points 20+ hours). The largest decreases in PIM for children aged 4 were in Gisborne (17 percentage points 10 hours or more and 7 percentage points 20 hours or more), Hawke's Bay (11 percentage points 10 hours or more and 5 percentage points 20 hours or more) and Taranaki (11 percentage points 10 hours or more) (Figure 16).

Figure 16: Changes in participation intensity (PIM) for children aged 4, between 2019 and 2025

Where to find out more

For more information about participation in early learning see the [Early learning participation](#) statistics page on Education Counts. For information on Ministry initiatives to increase early learning participation see the [Increasing participation in early learning](#) page on the Ministry of Education website. For a large range of other early learning statistics see:

- [Factsheets on the annual ECE census](#)
- [Directory of ECE service providers](#)
- [Statistics on services or providers of ECE](#)
- [Statistics on staffing in the ECE sector](#)
- [Publications from the Monitoring and Evaluating the Early Learning Action Plan \(ELAP\) programme](#)

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